



27-ONBOARDING-AND-FIRST-RUN.md — The ten minutes that decide everything



A photographer will give AURA one wedding to prove itself. If the first run is confusing, slow to first signal, or wrong in a way they cannot correct, they go back to Lightroom and never return. This file specifies those ten minutes with the same rigour as a rendering pipeline.

1. The one thing first run must achieve

Not a feature tour. Not a settings wizard. One thing:

The photographer sees AURA make a decision they agree with, on their own photographs, within 90 seconds of opening the app.

Everything below serves that sentence. Any screen that does not move toward it is cut.

2. The first-run sequence

Step	Elapsed	What happens	What must never happen
1. Launch	0:00	Window in ≤ 2 s. One question: "Point me at a wedding folder."	Account creation, login wall, email capture
2. Model download	0:00–3:00	Starts in background immediately, with a real size and time estimate	A blocking modal with an indeterminate spinner

Step	Elapsed	What happens	What must never happen
3. Folder choice	0:15	Drag-and-drop or picker. Instant validation: count, cameras, date range, estimated time	Silently accepting a Dropbox-synced folder
4. Consent	0:30	One screen. Default: everything local, nothing shared. "Continue" works with all toggles off	Dark patterns, pre-ticked boxes, a wall of legal text
5. First signal	0:45–1:30	The first 100 photos are culled and shown while the rest are still importing	A progress bar for 40 minutes before anything is visible
6. The agreement moment	1:30	Side-by-side: kept vs cut, with the reason for each. Thumbs up or down	Presenting decisions with no explanation
7. Calibration	2:00–5:00	Optional: 30 rapid keep/cut judgements that tune the thresholds to this photographer	Making it mandatory, or making it feel like homework
8. Let it run	5:00+	Honest remaining time; the app can be closed and resumed	"Do not close this window"

The 100-photo head start is the most important engineering decision in this document. It requires the pipeline to prioritise a representative sample — not the first 100 chronologically, which are all identical shots of an empty venue — but a spread across the day's timeline. Ship it even if it complicates the scheduler, because it converts a 40-minute act of faith into a 90-second demonstration.

3. The agreement moment, specified

This single screen carries the product.

- **Show cuts, not keeps.** Photographers trust software that keeps photos; they fear software that deletes them. Lead with what was removed and why, because that is where the anxiety lives.

- **Every cut states a reason in their language:** "eyes closed — 3 of 4 people", "duplicate of the sharper frame 2 s later", "missed focus on the subject". Never "score 0.31".
- **Every cut is one click from undo**, and undoing teaches the system.
- **Nothing is deleted, ever.** Cut means unflagged, not removed from disk. Say so, on screen, in the first run.
- **Show a confidence band, not a number.** "Confident" / "Fairly sure" / "Your call" maps to the autonomy bands and is honest about uncertainty in a way a decimal is not.

4. Empty states are features

State	What it shows
No projects yet	Drop zone plus "Try it on our sample wedding" — 300 licensed DEMO images, so the product can be evaluated before trusting it with real work
Models still downloading	Import and browsing work now; AI features show what they will do and when they will be ready
No GPU detected	Plain statement of what will be slower and by how much, with a measured estimate — not a warning triangle
Offline	Nothing at all. Offline is the normal case; the UI should not mention it
Run interrupted	"Resuming where you stopped: 2,847 of 4,000 already done." Never restart from zero

5. Refusals that build trust

The app should say no in four situations, and each is a trust-building moment rather than an obstacle:

1. **Catalog inside a cloud-synced folder.** Explain that Dropbox and OneDrive corrupt SQLite databases, and offer to place it correctly. This prevents your single most destructive support ticket.
2. **Destination disk lacks space.** Compute the actual requirement and say the number before starting, not at 3,800 of 4,000.

3. **Folder is on a disconnecting external drive over USB 2.** Warn with the measured read speed and the resulting time estimate.
4. **Fewer than 50 images.** Style learning will not be meaningful; say so honestly rather than producing a confidently bad result.

6. Progress that does not lie

Honest progress is a reliability invariant expressed in the UI:

- Report completed work units, never predicted percentages that stall at 99 %.
- Show the stage by name: "Reading RAW files", "Finding faces", "Choosing keepers".
- Estimates come from measured throughput on **this** machine in **this** run, and widen rather than lying when variance is high.
- Show a range once confidence is low: "about 25–35 minutes left".
- Cancel is immediate and safe; the work already done is kept.

7. Tests

- ☐ **Cold-start test:** fresh machine, no models, 4,000 images — first cull decision visible within 90 s, measured on T-Min.
- ☐ **Five-user test:** five photographers who have never seen AURA, no guidance, screen recorded. Every point of hesitation over 5 s is a bug with an owner.
- ☐ **Consent-off test:** complete the whole first run with every toggle off; nothing may be blocked or degraded beyond documented cloud features.
- ☐ **Interrupt test:** close the app at each of the eight steps; relaunch resumes correctly at every one.
- ☐ **Sample-project test:** the DEMO wedding runs fully offline before any real folder is chosen.
- ☐ **Honest-estimate test:** across 20 runs, the estimate shown at 25 % completion is within 20 % of actual.

8. Acceptance criteria

- ☐ Time to first cull decision ≤ 90 s on T-Typ, ≤ 150 s on T-Min, measured in CI on the golden corpus.
- ☐ No account, login or email is required to complete a full wedding.
- ☐ Every cut has a plain-language reason and a one-click undo.
- ☐ The word "delete" never appears in the cull flow, because nothing is deleted.
- ☐ All four refusals are implemented with actionable next steps.
- ☐ Five-user test completed and every hesitation point resolved or explicitly accepted.
- ☐ Calibration is optional and skippable, and skipping it is never punished with worse messaging.

9. Claude Code prompt

Act as **UX** (Design Lead) with **SFE** (Senior Frontend) implementing and **PM** reviewing. Implement **27-ONBOARDING-AND-FIRST-RUN.md** : the eight-step first-run sequence, the representative-sample scheduler that produces the 100-photo head start spread across the day's timeline, the agreement screen with reasons and one-click undo, all five empty states, all four refusals, and the honest-progress component.

Constraints: no blocking modal may ever wait on a network operation; the entire flow must complete with all consent toggles off; every reason string must be written for a photographer, and any string containing a raw score or a model name is a defect.

Then measure time-to-first-decision on the golden corpus on both T-Min and T-Typ and paste the numbers. Then act as **PM** and list every screen that does not serve the sentence in section 1, and delete it.